

312 CE

BATTLE OF THE MILVIAN BRIDGE

Diocletian's Tetrarchy (governance of the Roman Empire by four rulers) became destabilized after the death of Constantius I in 306 CE and the declaration of his son, Constantine, as emperor. A struggle ensued with Maxentius, son of Diocletian's former co-emperor Maximian, who claimed rule over the western empire. Allied with Licinius in the east, Constantine marched on Italy, defeating Maxentius in a battle at the Milvian Bridge outside Rome.



◀ Battle of the Milvian Bridge



330 CE

CONSTANTINE FOUNDS A NEW EASTERN ROMAN CAPITAL

After defeating Licinius, his last rival, Constantine I chose the site of the old Greek city of Byzantium to found a new capital to consolidate his rule. Calling it Nova Roma ("New Rome" – though it soon took his own name as Constantinople), he established a new Senate, and had a grand imperial place, baths, a vast Hippodrome and imposing Christian churches built there. The new city, the imperial capital for over 1,000 years, was embellished with statues taken from throughout the empire.

◀ Constantine's Column, Istanbul

320 CE Ezana of the Ethiopian kingdom of Aksum is converted to Christianity

325 CE The Council of Nicaea, a meeting of Christian bishops, agrees the first official Christian doctrine

359 CE

“No one whatsoever should be denied the opportunity to give his heart to the observance of that religion which he should think best for himself.”

THE EDICT OF MILAN, 313 CE

45-500 CE

THE SPREAD OF CHRISTIANITY

Christianity spreads from its Judaeen heartland in the mid-40s CE with missionary journeys by St Paul to Antioch and Asia Minor.

301 CE Armenia becomes first Christian state when its ruler Tiridates III is converted by St Gregory the Illuminator.



313 CE By the Edict of Milan, Constantine I tolerates Christianity and other religions in the Roman Empire.



391 CE Theodosius I bans pagan worship in the Roman Empire. Many temples are attacked and destroyed by Christian mobs.



497 CE The Frankish king Clovis converts to Christianity, accepting baptism into the Roman Catholic Church.